

Herons and relatives

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Pelecaniformes
FAMILIES	5
SPECIES	118

This group of water birds includes herons, egrets, bitterns, pelicans, ibises, and spoonbills. All have large, plump bodies with long necks and powerful bills. Their long legs help them wade in shallow water, where they feed on fish, amphibians, snails, and crabs. Most feed alone to avoid other birds disturbing their prey, but at night they gather in groups to roost, and many species breed in colonies. These birds are found in freshwater habitats throughout the world, mostly in warm regions not subject to winter freezing.

Anatomy

Herons and their relatives have several adaptations for walking and feeding in shallow water. Long legs allow the bird to keep its plumage dry while it extends its flexible neck to lower its head toward the water. The feet have 4 widely spaced toes, the front 3 joined by webbing that spreads the bird's weight as it walks on mud or marshy vegetation. All birds in this group have broad wings. During flight, herons, bitterns,

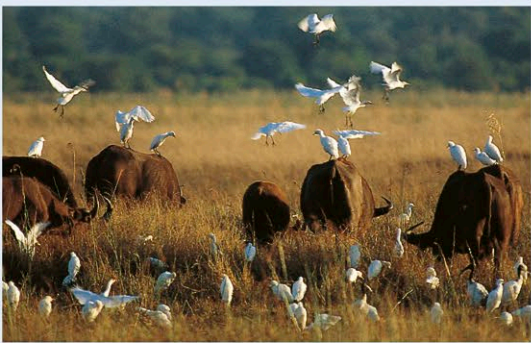
and egrets retract their neck, whereas all ibises and spoonbills hold them straight out.

Feeding

Most herons and their relatives use sharp eyesight to find their prey, scanning the water for signs of movement below the surface. Once sighted, a fish or frog will be grabbed (but rarely speared) with a thrust of the bill. Some birds refine the technique—for example, the black heron spreads its wings to cast a shadow on the water and lure fish

FEEDING INLAND

The western cattle egret finds most of its food away from water. Flocks typically gather around cattle and other large mammals to feed on insects disturbed by their movements.



into the shade. As a group, the order is represented on most wetland, coastal, and open terrestrial regions worldwide, with ibises generally favoring warmer latitudes. Those species found in the Northern Hemisphere are migratory, but species in the tropics are sedentary.

Breeding

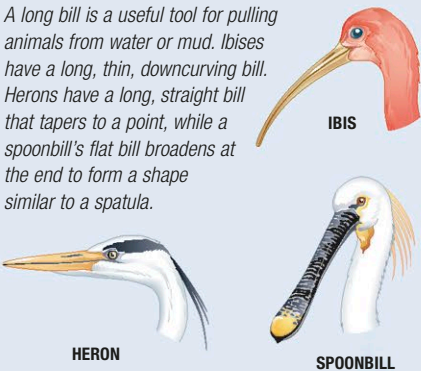
While many herons are gregarious and may breed in large colonies, bitterns—their close allies—lead more secretive solitary lives. Ibises and spoonbills are colonial. All members of the order are

monogamous and form tight pair bonds that may involve elaborate courtship displays. Their nests range from low-lying platforms among reedbeds to large, untidy stick-nests in trees. Both sexes incubate the eggs and care for their young—which hatch with at least a partial coat of down but are nevertheless helpless and must remain in the nest for a number of weeks.

The hamerkop and shoebill were formerly classified with storks, but are now thought to be allied to pelicans.

BILL SHAPES

A long bill is a useful tool for pulling animals from water or mud. Ibises have a long, thin, downcurving bill. Herons have a long, straight bill that tapers to a point, while a spoonbill's flat bill broadens at the end to form a shape similar to a spatula.



WADING

Herons and their relatives wade slowly and deliberately. Spoonbills (seen here) sweep the water with their bills, using touch-sensitive cells to find small fish and crustaceans.



Ardea cinerea

Gray heron



Location Europe, Asia, Africa

Length 90–98 cm (35–39 in)

Weight 1–2 kg (2¼–4½ lb)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Partial migrant

Status Least concern



The most common and widespread heron in Europe, this bird can be found in all kinds of shallow, freshwater habitats from reedbeds to lakes. It flies with slowly flapping, deeply bowed wings. Gray herons pair for life; the male and female build the nest together,

often in a tall tree, but sometimes on the ground. The female usually lays 3–5 eggs. Like other herons, they use ritual courtship and defense displays, such as stretching upward with an arching neck.



APPEARANCE

A large and distinctive bird, the gray heron has a long neck and long legs. Its plumage is gray, white, and black.

FISHING BY SIGHT

The gray heron relies on stealth and rapid reactions to catch its prey. When fishing, it stands close to the water's edge, monitoring the movement of any fish close by. If a fish comes within striking range, the heron tips forward and partly extends its neck, before suddenly stabbing with its bill. It swallows small fish whole, but takes larger ones back to land.

